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Philosophical Traditions

ROYAL INSTITUTE OF PHILOSOPHY SUPPLEMENT: 74

EDITED BY

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CAMBRIDGE
UNIVERSITY PRESS

2014.

with reality' along with *reliable success* in attaining it.⁶ The phrase, 'cognitive contact' is of course, broad enough to accommodate states like understanding and wisdom that aim at much more than picturing reality in propositional content. Yet for a start, the motivational component of intellectual virtue is best taken as a love of *truth*. The relevant point here is that love of truth (like all loves) tends to go awry in strange ways: Sliding into obsession, it can result in dogmatism; becoming overconfident and lazy, it can lead to fanciful generalizations; and tinged by jealousy, it can prevent truth from circulating. We therefore need regulative controls to keep this primary epistemological motivation on track. We need, in other words, to love in a *specific way* in order to succeed in attaining truth. This, according to virtue epistemologists, requires further dispositions that make us ascertain way *qua* epistemic agents. Our character traits, thus, orient us to the world in a manner that can lead to intellectual flourishing (or not). They do so by either directing us straightforwardly to epistemic ends or by overcoming psychological obstacles in achieving that goal.

What then are the specific intellectual virtues that sustain successful inquiry? Though this question arises in a particular moment in the history of Anglo American theories of knowledge, can we find a response to it in the *Mahābhārata*? The answer that is forthcoming comes, like most *Mahābhārata* answers, in the form of a story from the past: 'Once upon a time there lived a sage called Kausika...'

The Story of the Short Tempered Sage⁷

The learned Brahmin scholar, Kausika, once lost his temper when a hapless bird disturbed his meditation by defecating on his head. Incensed by this rude interruption, Kausika unleashed his supernatural powers on the unsuspecting bird and caused it to drop dead. But almost immediately he was overcome with compassion

⁶ Linda Zagzebski, *Virtues in the Mind: An Inquiry into the Nature of Virtue and the Ethical Foundation of Knowledge* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1996).

⁷ Vana Parvan, 197–216. Though the details of the narrative are important, what I present here is not a translation but a short summary of the story. All references to the *Mahābhārata* are from Ramchandra Shastri Kinnawadekar (ed.) *The Mahābhārata with Bharata Bhavadēpa Commentary of Nilakajha* (New Delhi: Oriental Books Reprint Corporation, n.d.).

From Good Knowers to Just Knowers in the *Mahābhārata*

and regret at such vengeance. Horrified by his own glaring limitations, Kausika decided to re-educate himself and embarked on a quest for instructors.

His travels led him to the village of a particular housewife. On arriving at her doorstep, the sage found her busy with household chores and the business of attending to the needs of her husband. An impatient Kausika stormed (once again!) – this time for having been kept waiting. The housewife, however, held her ground in the face of this entitled rage and even berated him for not being a true scholar. Even though she had not been told, she made it clear that she was aware of Kausika's infamous history with the bird. 'Nāham balākā' ('I am no bird!') she suggestively and sarcastically says in order to stem Kausika's diatribe – but later openly admits that she knew all along why Kausika had left his own village and come to her. Impressed by her clearly superior cognitive powers, Kausika accepted her strident criticisms of him. Filled with shame, he decided to follow her advice and seek out a particular butcher to help him restrain himself.

Kausika went to the butcher's town and encountered a humble, low-caste person skinning, chopping and selling animal carcasses. While practicing his trade, the butcher led a conventional life caring for his aging parents. But surprisingly, he became Kausika's teacher. The unlikely location of his simple and poor home transformed into a site for transmission of knowledge.

The story ends with a long speech in which the 'virtuous butcher' (*dharmaśyādhā*) explained the nature of righteousness, the nature of reality and the nature of non-violence. His parting advice was that Kausika should return to take care of his old parents and that this would not interfere with his study.

The (Epistemic) Moral of the Story

On the surface, this is an ethical tale – a story about a brahmin sage, Kausika, learning to control his rage and overcome his pride. According to a historically contextualised reading,⁸ the episode records adjustments made in Brahmanical theory in order to withstand criticisms being brought against the Vedic practice of animal sacrifice. Such critiques could have come from the renunciate precursors of Buddhism and Jainism who espoused absolute

⁸ Sibaji Bandyopadhyay, 'A Critique of Non-Violence', *Seminar* 608 (2010)

non-violence. The butcher's speech at the end of the episode is a skillful mediation between unavoidable violence and non-violence: it drives home for Kausika the 'true meaning' of non-aggression or *ahimsā*. This is an ethical message.

However, through a different lens, the story can be seen as plotted around the drama of epistemic displacement and epistemic transformations.⁹ It is about someone who, in spite of having the social capital of a high caste 'scholar', did not possess the intellectual virtues necessary for effective inquiry. It shows the re-tooling of an erudite but irate sage into a 'good knower' through engagement with individuals at the social margins. The ethical, here, seems to serve a deeper epistemic purpose.

But how can a narrative about pride and aggression speak to the problem of knowledge – not just moral knowledge – but of knowledge pertaining to garden-variety plain truths about sticks and stones? In fact, the didactic portions of the *Mahābhārata* often render the very notion of the 'epistemic' nebulous because of the manner in which they speak of truth (*satya*) – the designated goal of cognitive activity. The *Mahābhārata* routinely embeds truth in a list of ethical virtues and sometimes openly dismisses truth-speaking in favor of moral virtues like non-cruelty. Let us look more carefully at the worry that a notion of alethic truth might be absent in the *Mahābhārata*. This is important because without an independent notion of 'truth', endeavors and concepts that define themselves in terms of 'cognitive contact with reality' become shaky.

In response to the direct questions: What is truth? How is it obtained?, the Śānti Parvan in chapter 162.1–26 lists and defines thirteen moral virtues, calling them the thirteen 'Ways of truth' or *satya-ācāra*¹⁰ (*satya* meaning 'truth' and *ācāra* meaning 'ways of conduct' or 'practice'.) The list comprises of standard ethical qualities like impartiality, freedom from envy, self-control, patience, and the like. Now, this can easily be made sense of in a virtue-theoretic framework. Cognitive success depends on possessing thirteen character traits which are the *ways/means* to truth. We are often biased, lazy, hasty. We are also prone to fantasy, wishful thinking, and deceit. Such proclivities routinely scramble 'cognitive contact with reality.' Moral virtues (like the thirteen listed) become 'virtues

⁹ Virinda Dalmiya and Linda Alcoff, 'Are "Old Wives" Tales Justified?' in Linda Alcoff and Elizabeth Potter (eds) *Feminist Epistemologies* (New York: Routledge, 1993), 217–244 gives an epistemological reading of the episode which is different from the one suggested here.

¹⁰ Verse 6: *ācārāṇiḥa satyasya yathāvadānupūrvasāḥ*.